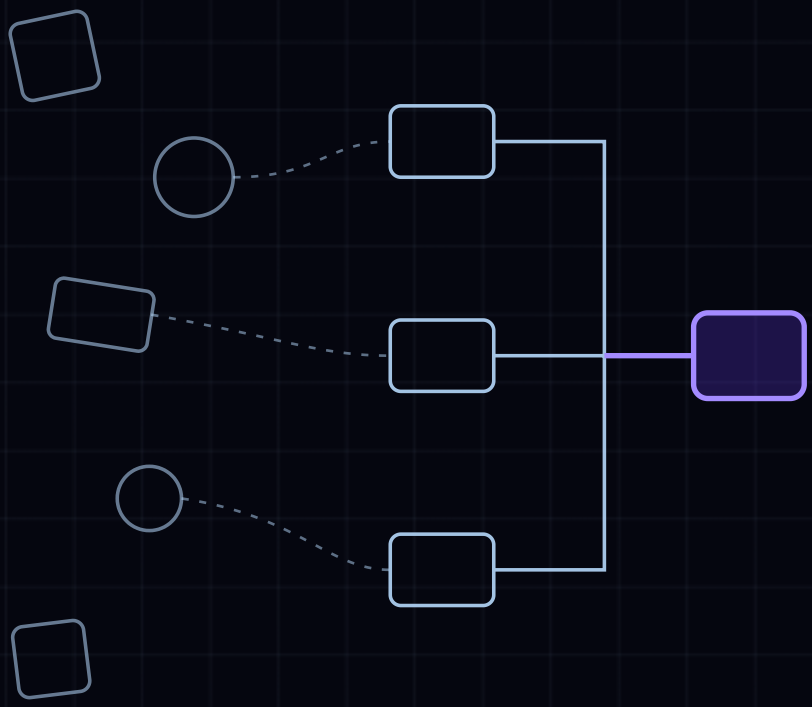


FREE GUIDE · PRACTICAL AI

The AI Strategy Starter

for Founders & Leaders

Work out where AI actually fits in your business: the questions to ask first, how to pick your first three workflows, and the mistakes that sink most AI pilots.

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START HERE

Most AI strategies fail quietly.

Not because the model was wrong. Usually it's because nobody decided what the AI was actually for, who would own it, or how it would fit into the way people already work.

This guide is the thinking I do with founders and leadership teams before anyone writes a line of code or signs a vendor contract. It works whichever model, tool or platform you end up choosing. There are no tool lists, no hype and no vendor pitches.

Who it's for

Founders, managers and leadership teams deciding where AI should go first, and anyone stepping into an AI strategy role.

How to use it

10 minutes: read the 5 questions (pages 4–5).
60 minutes: work through the worksheets with your team and finish with a 30/60/90-day plan.

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Why AI pilots stall

The demo works. Everyone's impressed. Three months later, nobody's using it. Here are the five patterns behind most stalled AI projects.

01 It started with the technology, not the work

"We should be using AI" is not a starting point. "Our team spends 15 hours a week rewriting the same client reports" is. Projects that begin with a tool go looking for a problem, and rarely find one worth the effort.

02 The demo skipped the messy parts

Real work is full of exceptions: missing fields, odd formats, the customer who always emails at midnight. A pilot that only handled the clean cases hasn't really been tested yet.

03 Nobody owned it after the pilot

The pilot team moves on, and the workflow has no one to fix it, improve it or defend it in the next budget meeting. Without a named owner, even good pilots fade.

04 Security and compliance came last

The project is "almost ready" when someone finally asks where the data goes. Then everything stops. Questions that take a day to answer at the start can take months at the end.

05 Nobody defined what "working" means

Without a baseline (how long the task takes today, how often it goes wrong), you can't show the AI is better. And if you can't show it, it won't survive the next round of priorities.

The fix isn't a better model. It's asking better questions before you start, which is exactly what the next two pages are for.

The 5 questions to ask before any AI project

Answer these for every AI idea on your list. If you can't answer one, that's your first piece of work, not a reason to skip it.

Q1 What specific work are we trying to change?

Name the task, who does it, and how often. "Customer support" is a department; "drafting first replies to refund requests" is a task.

WEAK "Use AI to improve our sales process."

STRONG "Turn sales-call recordings into CRM notes and follow-up emails. 6 reps, about 40 calls a week."

Q2 What does it cost us today?

Hours per week, delays, errors, missed revenue, unhappy customers. This is your baseline, and the number you'll compare against later.

WEAK "It takes a lot of time."

STRONG "About 20 minutes per call to write notes, roughly 13 hours a week across the team, and follow-ups often go out a day late."

Q3 What would "good" look like in 90 days?

Pick one measurable outcome. Not "transform sales", but a number you can check.

WEAK "Reps are more productive."

STRONG "Notes and follow-ups ready within an hour of every call, with reps spending under 5 minutes reviewing them."

Q4 What can go wrong, and who has to say yes?

Think about data (is it sensitive, personal or confidential?), customers (what if the AI gets it wrong in front of them?), and people (who must approve: security, legal, compliance, the team who'll use it?).

WEAK "We'll figure out security later."

STRONG "Call recordings contain client details, so we need sign-off from our security lead, and reps must approve every email before it's sent."

Q5 Who owns it after launch?

One named person, not a committee, who is responsible for the workflow working, improving and being used. Ideally someone from the team that does the work, not only IT.

WEAK "The innovation team."

STRONG "Priya, our sales ops lead, owns it, with 2 hours a week set aside to review quality and feedback."

How to read your answers

IF…	IT MEANS…
You can answer all five clearly	It's a strong candidate. Take it to the scoring step on page 7.
You can't name the task (Q1) or the cost (Q2)	It's an idea, not a project yet. Spend a week watching how the work actually happens.
Q4 has a blocker nobody can approve	Park it, or start with a lower-risk version (internal use only, with human review).
Nobody will own it (Q5)	Don't start. An unowned pilot is the most common way AI projects die.

Tip: run these questions with the people who do the work, not just the people who manage it. The best answers to Q1 and Q2 almost always come from the front line.

Find the real candidates

Before choosing what to automate, list what your team actually spends time on. Pick one or two teams and write down 10–15 recurring tasks.

Good AI candidates usually are…

- **Repetitive:** done daily or weekly
- **Text- or document-heavy:** emails, reports, forms, notes
- **Rules plus some judgment:** too fuzzy for simple automation
- **Clear in, clear out:** you know what goes in and what a good result looks like
- **Slowed by handoffs:** work waits in someone's inbox

Poor first candidates are usually…

- **Rare:** a few times a year
- **High-stakes with no review:** legal, medical or financial decisions made automatically
- **Missing data:** the information isn't written down anywhere
- **Relationship-driven:** the value is the human conversation
- **Still changing:** the process itself isn't settled yet

Workflow inventory

TASK	TEAM	HOW OFTEN	TIME EACH	INPUTS	PAIN TODAY
e.g. Summarise sales calls into CRM notes	Sales	40 / week	20 min	Call recording	Late follow-ups
e.g. Check supplier invoices against POs	Finance	150 / month	8 min	Invoice PDF, PO	Errors, delays

Quick maths for "cost today": how often × time each = hours per week. That number is your baseline.

Pick your first 3 workflows

Score each candidate from your inventory from 1 (low) to 5 (high) on five things. Then pick your top three, including at least one quick win.

CRITERION	ASK YOURSELF
Value	If this worked perfectly, how much time, money or customer pain would it save?
Frequency	How often does this task happen? Daily beats monthly.
Data ready	Is the information it needs already digital, accessible and reasonably clean?
Low risk	If the AI makes a mistake, is it easy to catch and cheap to fix? (5 = very safe)
Ease	Can a small team ship a working version in weeks, not quarters?

Illustrative example: a 60-person B2B services firm

WORKFLOW	VALUE	FREQ.	DATA	RISK	EASE	TOTAL
Sales calls → CRM notes and follow-ups	4	5	4	4	4	**21**
First drafts of replies to support tickets	4	5	4	3	4	**20**
Invoice vs purchase-order checks	3	4	3	4	3	**17**
Quarterly board report drafting	3	1	2	3	3	12
Automated pricing decisions	5	3	2	1	1	12

Why the top three win

They happen often, the data already exists, and mistakes are easy to catch because a person reviews the output before it goes anywhere.

Why pricing waits

Highest value on paper, but risky, hard to build and short on clean data. Come back to it once the team trusts AI on safer work.

Your top three

#	WORKFLOW	SCORE	OWNER
1			
2			
3			

Buy, configure, build or wait

For each of your top three, choose an approach. The right answer depends on how common the task is, how sensitive the data is, and how much it matters to your edge.

APPROACH	CHOOSE IT WHEN…	WATCH OUT FOR…
Buy an off-the-shelf tool	The task is common (meeting notes, email drafting), a good tool already exists, and the data isn't highly sensitive.	Where your data is stored and whether it's used for training; per-seat costs as you grow.
Configure a platform you already use	Your CRM, helpdesk or workspace already has AI features that fit, with light setup.	Features that demo well but don't match your real process; lock-in.
Build a custom workflow	The workflow is core to how you compete, uses your own data or process, or needs tight control over security and actions.	Underestimating maintenance, evaluation and the human review step.
Wait	The data isn't ready, the process keeps changing, or nobody can own it yet.	Waiting forever. Set a date to revisit, and fix the blocker in the meantime.

Count the whole cost, not just the licence

- Licences or model usage
- Setup and integration with your systems
- Time people spend reviewing AI output
- Ongoing maintenance and monitoring
- Security and compliance review
- Training the team to use it well

A simple test: if the workflow disappeared tomorrow, would a competitor be able to copy it in a week with an off-the-shelf tool? If yes, buy. If no, it's probably worth building, carefully.

Design a pilot that sticks

Fill in this canvas for your number-one workflow before the pilot starts. If a box is empty, the pilot isn't ready yet.

WORKFLOW

The specific task, from Q1.

OWNER

One named person, from Q5.

PILOT USERS

The 3–10 real people who will use it from day one.

BASELINE

How long it takes and how often it goes wrong today, from Q2.

SUCCESS METRIC

The one number that tells you it worked, from Q3.

HUMAN IN THE LOOP

Where a person reviews or approves before anything leaves the building.

GUARDRAILS

What the AI must never do (e.g. send to clients without approval, touch payment data).

DATA AND ACCESS

Which systems and data it needs, and who approved that access.

DECISION AT DAY 30

Scale it, fix and extend it, or stop it. Agree the criteria now, before anyone gets attached.

Four rules for pilots that last

1. **Use real work from day one.** Test on live tasks with the people who do them, not on a cleaned-up sample.
2. **Keep a human approval step at first.** Remove it only when the numbers show you can.
3. **Measure against the baseline weekly.** Time saved, error rate and how often people actually use it.
4. **Collect the failures.** Every bad output is a test case for the next version.

Get past security on day one

Security and compliance teams aren't there to block you. They're asking the questions your customers will ask later. Answer these before you build, not after.

THE QUESTION THEY'LL ASK	WHAT A GOOD ANSWER LOOKS LIKE
Where does our data go?	You can name every system and AI provider the data passes through, and where it's stored.
Is our data used to train someone else's model?	No, and it's in the contract or settings, not just a sales promise.
What can the AI actually do?	A clear list of the systems it can read from or act on, with the least access needed.
Who approved each action?	Sensitive actions need a human sign-off, and you can see who gave it.
Can we prove what happened?	Every AI action and output is logged, so you can check what was done and why.
What happens when it's wrong?	Mistakes are caught by review before they reach customers, and there's a way to report and fix them.
How do we switch it off?	One clear way to pause it, and the old process still works.
Which rules apply to us?	You've checked the data-protection rules for your market (e.g. India's DPDP Act, GDPR in Europe) and any industry rules.

Why this matters so much: in larger companies, these questions, not the technology, are usually what decides whether an AI project ships. It's also the problem I'm building **Taskflo AI** to solve: AI agent workflows that run inside a company's own cloud, with every action checked and logged.

Your 30/60/90-day AI plan

Turn everything so far into a plan your team can actually run. Keep it to one page and review it every two weeks.

DAYS 1–30

Decide & prepare

- Answer the 5 questions for your top ideas
- Pick your first 3 workflows and owners
- Record the baselines
- Run the security questions
- Choose buy, configure or build
- Start the pilot for workflow #1

DAYS 31–60

Pilot & measure

- Run #1 on real work with real users
- Track the success metric weekly
- Collect failures and fix them
- Prepare workflow #2
- Share early results with leadership

DAYS 61–90

Scale or stop

- Day-30 style decision on #1: scale, fix or stop
- Launch #2; plan #3
- Train the wider team
- Write down what you learned
- Set the next 90-day goals

Your plan

	DAYS 1–30	DAYS 31–60	DAYS 61–90
Goal			
Workflow			
Owner			
Metric			
Risks			
Decision			

09 / AVOID THESE

10 mistakes that sink AI pilots

I see these again and again. Most of them are about people and process, not technology.

01 Starting with a tool instead of a task

Pick the work first, then the technology.

02 Picking the flashiest use case first

Start where mistakes are cheap and value is frequent. Build trust, then aim higher.

03 Testing on clean, made-up examples

Use real, messy work from day one, or you're testing a fantasy.

04 No baseline

If you didn't measure before, you can't prove anything after.

05 Leaving security to the end

Bring them in during week one. It's faster overall.

06 Removing the human too early

Keep review in place until the numbers say otherwise.

07 Building for the team instead of with them

The people doing the work know where it breaks. Involve them from the start.

08 No owner after launch

Name one person, and give them time to look after it.

09 Running ten pilots at once

Three focused pilots beat ten half-finished ones.

10 Never deciding

Every pilot ends with a clear call: scale, fix or stop. "Let's keep watching" is how budgets drain away.

The one-page checklist

Print this, stick it on the wall, and don't start building until most of the boxes are ticked.

Before you start

- [ ] We've named the specific task, not just the department
- [ ] We know what it costs us today (our baseline)
- [ ] We've agreed one measurable 90-day outcome
- [ ] We know what could go wrong, and who must approve
- [ ] One named person owns it after launch

Choosing

- [ ] We listed 10–15 real tasks from 1–2 teams
- [ ] We scored them and picked a top three
- [ ] At least one of the three is a quick win
- [ ] We chose buy, configure, build or wait for each
- [ ] We counted the whole cost, not just licences

Security

- [ ] We know where the data goes, and it isn't used for training
- [ ] The AI has only the access it needs
- [ ] Sensitive actions need human approval
- [ ] Every action is logged
- [ ] There's a clear way to switch it off

Pilot

- [ ] The pilot canvas is fully filled in
- [ ] Real users, real work from day one
- [ ] A human reviews output at first
- [ ] We track the metric weekly
- [ ] We've agreed the day-30 decision criteria

NEXT STEPS

Want help turning this into a plan?

I'm Pranjal. I've been building software since I was 15, started my first company at 19, and today I help founders and companies turn AI pilots into workflows their teams actually use. I'm also building Taskflo AI and doing a PhD at IIT Jodhpur in multi-agent systems.

Free 30-minute intro call

For leaders and teams with a stalled AI pilot or a "should we even use AI for this?" question. You'll get an honest first read and a written next step.

→ ipranjal.com/call

AI Strategy Planning session · 90 min

We work through this guide on your business together. You'll leave with your top 3 opportunities and a written 30/60/90-day plan.

→ ipranjal.com/session

AI Career & Portfolio Kickstart · 60 min

Moving into AI or workflow automation? Get a clear direction, portfolio project ideas and a learning plan.

→ ipranjal.com/session

Questions or feedback on this guide? Reply to any of my emails or write to hello@ipranjal.com. I read everything.

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